Teaching Statement

Tom Zohar, CEMFI, October 2026

I teach economics the way I learned to do research: by making students produce it. My first students were high-school and undergraduate tutees in Israel, among them a class of special-needs students to whom I taught math, and what they taught me is still my starting point: explain the concept in the simplest terms, then adapt to the student in front of you. At Stanford I taught sections in labor economics and then spent two years as head TA of the Economics Department, mentoring the department's TAs, which turned a taste for teaching into a method. At CEMFI, where I have taught since 2021, that method has one organizing idea: a student learns a field by trying to add to it. Every course I teach has a research-production component, from weekly research ideas to a term paper, and the classroom runs like a seminar, with students presenting, discussing and being called on, so that the habits of a professional economist are practiced rather than described.

Two things have changed in how I teach since my first teaching statement. First, I now put as much weight on judgment as on technique. Generative AI has collapsed the cost of execution, of coding, cleaning and first drafts, while the judgment that makes a result defensible is no easier to acquire. My courses therefore ask students to delegate execution and never delegate judgment, and grade them on how well they catch what the tools got wrong. Second, I teach writing explicitly. A paper's fate is largely decided in its first two pages, and most students have never been taught how to write them.

Graduate teaching at CEMFI

Labor Economics (second-year graduate course, 2021 to present). The course covers inequality and its measurement, intergenerational mobility, human capital, household economics and the core labor models, but its stated goal is to move students from consumers to producers of research. For five weeks every student submits a short research idea, the question, the intuition and a sketch of the implementation, and is assigned a classmate's idea to improve rather than to criticize. Each week two students present a paper in five slides, the what, the main insight, the good, the bad and the extension, and I call on others at random to discuss it, so the room works like a seminar. The term paper is built in three steps, a two-page proposal, a presentation of early results and a terse empirical paper, written in pairs so that every student is a primary author once and a coauthor once, with mandatory TA feedback before each step. Students book office hours only after sending a one-pager, and I meet each of them for coffee early in the term.

Research Workshop (second-year Master's course, 2026). I redesigned this course for the transition from coursework to the Master's thesis in a world of AI tools. Its rule is: delegate execution, never delegate judgment. Over an intensive first week each student takes a project of their own from an empty folder to a four-minute talk, one number and one figure they are willing to be cross-examined on, and the primary deliverable is an error log of what the AI got wrong and how they caught it. Later parts of the course cover writing the paper and presenting a replication package for the thesis.

Academic writing workshop for job-market candidates (2023 to present). I started this workshop in my role as placement officer. In three modules, candidates write a one-page research plan, turn it into an outline of headings and takeaways, and then draft and rewrite their introduction paragraph by paragraph against a set of sample introductions, with written feedback at each step.

Applied-micro student workshop (2021 to present). A weekly workshop in which PhD students present work in progress at every stage, from a two-slide idea to a job-market talk, and receive

structured feedback from faculty and peers. I organize it alongside CEMFI's applied micro seminar.

Undergraduate teaching

Topics in Labor Economics, Honors Class (Reichman University, 2025). A compact version of my graduate course for honors undergraduates, in four lectures: inequality of opportunity, the sorting of workers to firms, and family-formation decisions, each taught from a few papers read closely. The assessment is a two-page research proposal, one page on the paper in its best-case scenario and one on data, empirical strategy and identification, designed as a building block for the BA thesis.

CEMFI Summer School of Economics (Santander, 2024). Two lectures for advanced undergraduates and early graduate students: intergenerational mobility in historical and international perspective, and differential access to better-paying firms and its implications for inequality. Both are built around my own work, so students see how a research question turns into a paper.

Before my PhD I taught more than a hundred high-school and undergraduate students, and at Stanford I taught sections in labor economics and served two years as head TA of the Economics Department, where I ran the TA training and observed and coached the department's TAs.

Advising and mentoring

Advising is where I spend most of my teaching time. I am the main advisor of five PhD students, two of whom have finished, with placements as a postdoctoral fellow at Trinity College and at Yale followed by the University of Vienna; I serve on the committees of eight others and have supervised six Master's theses. My advising model is to work with students as coauthors: the *Journal of Development Economics* paper is joint with two of my graduate students, the separations paper with a PhD advisee, the digital-inclusion evaluation with a recent CEMFI graduate, and the model-based-outcomes paper with a PhD student. Since 2021 I have been CEMFI's placement officer, which means preparing every job-market cohort of the last five years, from the first draft of the job-market paper to the flyout; the writing workshop grew out of that role.

Evidence

In 2025 CEMFI named me Teacher of the Year. All CEMFI faculty are evaluated by their students on their graduate courses, and at the end of the year a committee chaired by the head of the Master's program selects the one instructor with the best reviews.

My graduate Labor Economics course has received a global assessment of 4.9, 4.9 and 4.6 out of 5 in the last three years, above the average of all courses in its term each year, with 86 to 100 percent of students rating the difficulty and pace as adequate. The comments repeat three themes: the course turns students into producers of research ("Best class at Cemfi by a long shot"; "teaches us to do research from scratch, an amazing and invaluable skill"), expectations and feedback are clear and continuous ("This level of clarity is rare in most CEMFI courses"), and students feel cared for ("very generous with his time"). The full summary with scores by year and quotes is enclosed.

Courses I can teach

At the undergraduate level I would be glad to teach labor economics, the economics of inequality and gender, introductory microeconomics and econometrics. At the graduate level, labor economics,

applied econometrics, and research and writing workshops of the kind described above. In a policy school, program evaluation with administrative data.